

TABLE 3 Effective Treatments for Cold Symptoms in Adults

Treatment	Dosing	Duration of treatment	Study findings
Acetaminophen	500 to 1,000 mg	Single dose	Cochrane review without data pooling of 4 low- to moderate-quality trials with outcome assessment at 3 to 6 hours found improvement in nasal obstruction and rhinorrhea but not in other symptoms; no numeric data provided ²²
Antihistamine plus decongestant	Varies	Variable	Cochrane review of 12 trials, including 6 placebo controlled with pooled data, found odds ratio of treatment failure = 0.27 (95% CI, 0.15 to 0.50); number needed to treat = 4, but 41% favorable response in placebo group ²³
Inhaled ipratropium (Atrovent)	4 20-g puffs 4 times per day	3 weeks	One small, randomized, double-blind crossover trial (N = 14) found significant reduction in persistent cough ²⁴
Intranasal oxymetazoline	2 sprays (0.05%) per nostril 1 or 2 times per day	Up to 10 days	Cochrane review of 15 trials (N = 1,838) found no improvement in nasal congestion with single use, but small improvement vs. placebo after multiple doses (SMD = 0.49; 95% CI, 0.07 to 0.92) ²⁵
<i>Lactobacillus casei</i> (for older adults)	200 g per day of fermented dairy product containing <i>L. casei</i>	3 months	RCT of 1,072 older adults found significant improvement in duration of colds and in cumulative days with colds when taken daily ²⁶
Nonsteroidal anti-	Varies	Varies from single	Cochrane review of 9

Treatment	Dosing	Duration of treatment	Study findings
inflammatory drugs		dose to 7 days	moderate-quality RCTs (N = 1,069) found no effect on total symptom score or cough, but improved sneezing (SMD = −0.44; 95% CI, −0.75 to −0.12), headache (SMD = −0.65; 95% CI, −1.11 to −0.19), and ear, muscle, and joint pain (SMD = −0.40; 95% CI, −0.77 to −0.03) vs. placebo ²⁷
Zinc acetate or gluconate	Varies; typically 80 to 92 mg per day	Start within 3 days of symptom onset and continue as long as symptoms persist	3 systematic reviews and meta-analyses found similar improvement in symptom duration (by about one-third) and mixed conclusions on symptom severity ^{28–30}

RCT = randomized controlled trial; SMD = standardized mean difference.

Information from references [22–30](#).